

Concept Testing

Research Overview:

- **Research Goal**

1. Evaluate the overall appeal of the game concept
2. Assess clarity of gameplay and narrative
3. Identify potential confusion or areas for improvement

- **Research Question**

1. Which game concept is most appealing to players?
2. Does the visual style effectively convey the intended mood and atmosphere?
3. Do players understand the core gameplay based on the concept?
4. Is the narrative clear and easy to follow?
5. What aspects of the concept are confusing or unclear?
6. How does this concept compare to other games players have experienced?

Method: Survey (20 participants ; 4 participants per person)

We chose a survey-based method because it allows us to efficiently collect responses from a relatively larger sample (n = 20) and capture participants' initial impressions of the concept, including its appeal, clarity, and how engaging or interesting it feels to players.

Recruitment Method

Participants will be recruited through online channels such as University of Michigan student group chats and other university-related communities, as well as through personal networks that meet the study criteria.

Each team member will recruit at least 4 participants, resulting in a total of approximately 20 participants for the study.

Screening questions will be used to ensure that all participants meet the inclusion criteria.

Include Criteria:

Participants must meet all of the following:

- ☐ Current University of Michigan student (to focus on college student players)
- ☐ Age between 18–22 (to focus on the primary college-age audience)
- ☐ Plays video games at least 1–7 hours per week (to ensure sufficient familiarity with games)
- ☐ Familiar with basic game controls (keyboard/mouse or controller)(to ensure they can understand the basic gameplay concepts)
- ☐ Plays at least one of the following genres:
(to ensure participants have experience with similar game types and mechanics)
 - ☐ Action / Combat
 - ☐ Casual
 - ☐ RPG
 - ☐ Adventure

- ☐ FPS
- ☐ MMO

Exclude Criteria:

Participants will be excluded if they meet any of the following:

- ☐ Not a University of Michigan student (outside the target user group)
- ☐ Age below 18 or above 22 (outside the defined age range)
- ☐ Plays video games less than 1 hour per week (insufficient engagement with games)
- ☐ No familiarity with basic game controls (keyboard/mouse or controller)
- ☐ Does not play any of the following genres:
 - ☐ Action / Combat
 - ☐ Casual
 - ☐ RPG
 - ☐ Adventure
 - ☐ FPS
 - ☐ MMO

Screening Survey:

- Are you currently a student at the University of Michigan?
 - Yes
 - No
- What is your age range?
 - under 18
 - 18-22
 - 23-30
 - 30+
- How many hours per week do you play video games?
 - 0 hours
 - 1–3 hours
 - 4–7 hours
 - 8–14 hours
 - 15+ hours
- Are you familiar with basic video game controls (e.g., keyboard/mouse or controller)?
 - Yes
 - No
- What type of games do you usually play? (Select all that apply)
 - Action / Combat
 - Casual
 - RPG
 - Adventure
 - FPS
 - MMO
 - Other: _____

- I don't usually play games

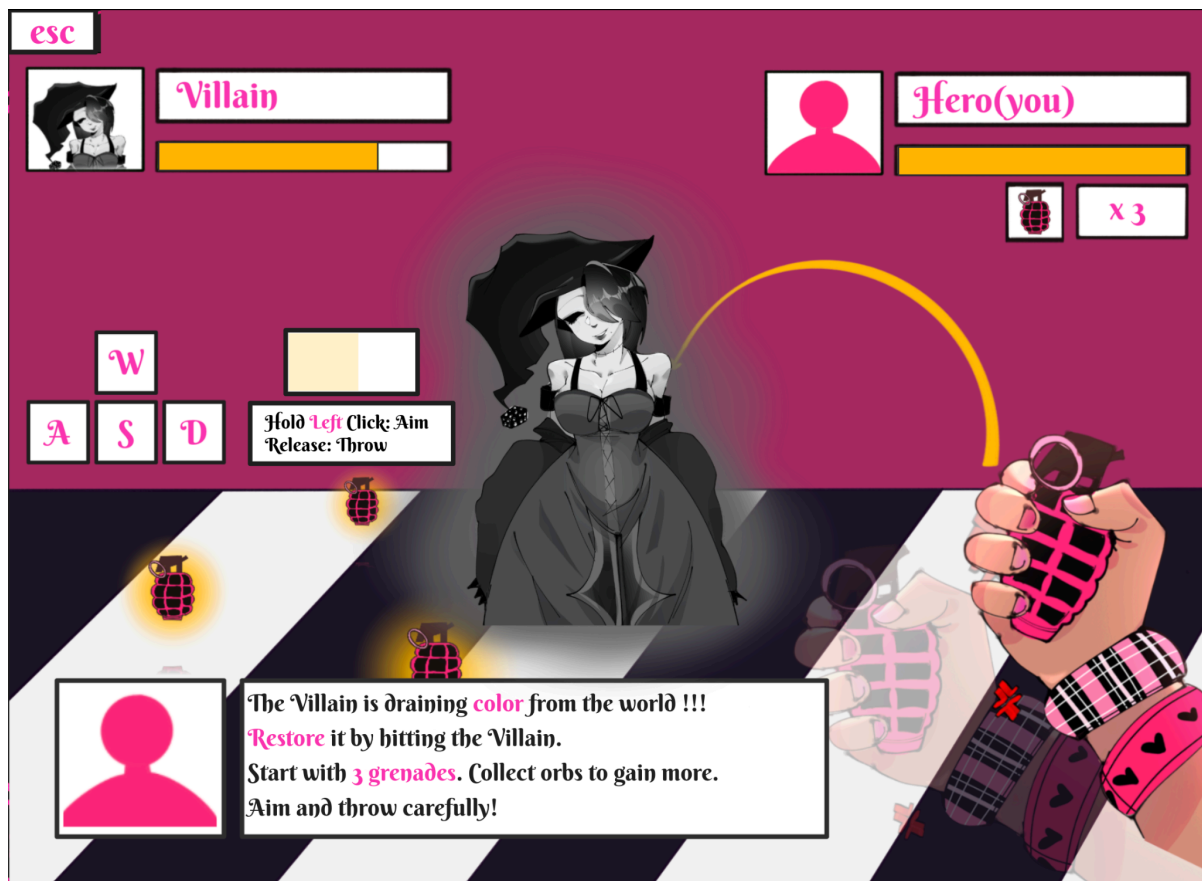
Testing Material

This study uses a static concept test, where participants are shown a preliminary concept image.

The image includes:

- The main character and villain design (color vs. grayscale contrast)
- Basic gameplay elements (grenade mechanic and trajectory indication)
- Early UI elements (health bars, grenade count, and control hints such as WASD and Left click)

The image is intended to communicate the core gameplay idea, visual style, and overall concept of the game.



Concept Testing Survey Questions

Section 1: First Impression

1. What is your first impression of this game concept?

Section 2: Visual Style & Atmosphere

2. How does the visual style feel to you? Why?
3. Do you think the visuals match the overall setting or atmosphere of the game? Why or why not?
4. What kind of mood or feeling do you get from this game?

Section 3: Gameplay Clarity

5. Based on what you saw, what do you think the player does in this game?
6. How clear is the gameplay to you?
 - Very clear
 - Somewhat clear
 - Neutral
 - Somewhat unclear
 - Very unclear

Section 4: Character & Narrative

7. What do you think is happening in this game?
8. Based on what you saw, is the narrative easy to understand?
 - Very easy
 - Somewhat easy
 - Difficult

Section 5: Differentiation / Appeal

9. How does this concept compare to other games you have seen or played?

Section 6: Open Feedback

10. Which elements of the concept do you find most appealing? Why?
11. Is there anything confusing or unclear?

Procedure:

Participants will first complete a screening survey to determine eligibility. Those who meet the inclusion criteria will be invited to complete the concept testing survey.

Participants will be shown a concept image along with a short description of the game before answering the survey questions.

The survey is expected to take approximately 10 minutes to complete. All responses will be collected for analysis.

Data Analysis Plan

Quantitative and qualitative data will be analyzed to identify key patterns in participants' perceptions of our game concept.

1. Quantitative Analysis

Responses from rating questions will be summarized using descriptive statistics, including frequency counts and percentage distributions.

Specifically:

- Responses to the gameplay clarity question ("How clear is the gameplay to you?") will be analyzed by calculating how many participants selected each level (very clear, somewhat clear, unclear)
- Responses to the narrative clarity question ("Is the narrative easy to understand?") will be analyzed in the same way to identify overall understanding of the game concept

The results will be presented using simple visualizations such as bar charts to highlight overall trends in clarity and understanding.

2. Thematic Analysis (Open-Ended Responses)

Open-ended responses will be reviewed and coded to identify recurring themes.

Responses will be grouped into categories such as:

- Visual appeal (color, art style, character design)
- Gameplay understanding
- Narrative interpretation
- Confusion or unclear elements

The frequency of each theme will be counted to identify the most common patterns across participants.

3. First Impression & Appeal Analysis

Participants' first impressions and appealing elements will be analyzed qualitatively by identifying:

- Common positive reactions
- Frequently mentioned appealing features
- Any repeated concerns or negative feedback

Representative quotes will be selected to support key findings.

4. Cross-Question Insights

Responses will be compared across sections to identify relationships, such as:

- Whether participants who found the gameplay unclear also reported confusion in open-ended responses
- Whether visual impressions align with perceived atmosphere

5. **Outcome Focus**

The analysis will focus on addressing the research goals by identifying:

- Overall appeal of the concept
- Clarity of gameplay and instructions
- Understanding of the narrative
- Key areas of confusion or misunderstanding

Findings from this study will be used to inform future design iterations and improvements.

Limitations

This study focuses on early impressions of the game concept rather than actual gameplay experience. As a result, findings reflect participants' initial perceptions and may not fully represent how players would interact with the game in a playable version.

The sample is limited to University of Michigan students aged 18–22, which may not represent a broader player population. Therefore, the results may be more reflective of college-aged players and may not generalize to other demographics.

Additionally, responses are based on a single concept image. This may limit participants' understanding of the full gameplay experience and lead to varied interpretations of the concept.